



Promising prospect: Tingmila DOUNGEL was one of the star pupils at the academy run by the Olympic bronze medallist Mary Kom.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

'My dreams were so big'

While Joel is still pushing to fulfil his sporting ambitions, Tingmila DOUNGEL has all but come to terms with the end of hers. DOUNGEL, now 23, is a student in Chennai, studying for a diploma at the YMCA College of Physical Education. Her horizons were once much broader.

"When I was boxing, my dream was so big. I wanted to become an Olympic and world champion. That was my dream. But this conflict is going on, so everything is like...", she says, without completing the sentence.

While it is true that even before the civil conflict, there were relatively fewer high-level non-football sportspersons compared to their more numerous Meitei counterparts (every Kuki-Zo member of the 2022 National Games squad, for instance,

competed in the football competition), Tingmila was one of the exceptions.

Hailing from Saikhul Hill town, Tingmila doesn't recall any sporting infrastructure in her town. "One day, though, I saw the *Mary Kom* movie and I wanted to be just like her. I used to run and train like she did until one day my grandfather took me for selection trials at the Mary Kom Academy," she says.

Tingmila would go on to become one of the star pupils at the academy run by the Olympic bronze medallist in Imphal's National Games Village, winning silver medals at the Khelo India Youth Games in 2018 and 2019. "I think my happiest moment was when I represented India. I competed and won gold at the Silesia Cup in the junior category. That same year, Mary Kom ma'am also took part in the senior category. That was so special," she recalls.

While the COVID pandemic halted her progress, Tingmila was still the best boxer in the 48kg weight category in Manipur. She represented the state at the 2022 National Championships and was also the senior state champion in the same weight class (that, incidentally, Mary had won five world titles in) in February 2023.

It was just a small step, but Tingmila had much bigger ambitions. She recalls a poster on the walls of her academy. "They were Mary Kom ma'am's words: 'Just because you are a woman, doesn't mean that there is anything you can't do.' I really liked that quote by Mary Kom ma'am. I wanted to be just like her," she says.

Those hopes ended on May 3. As mobs rampaged across Imphal, Tingmila and a few of her academy teammates from the same community hid in their academy's garage. "There were six or seven of us there. We hid for three days before the Assam Rifles soldiers rescued us and took us away. After I got out of Imphal and got back to my village in Saikhul, I didn't go anywhere. Sometimes, I would help as a volunteer at the town's self-defence unit. My two friends,

who were also boxers, and I were serving tea and cleaning the office," she says.

Tingmila says she once thought she would be able to return to boxing soon enough. "I didn't think the conflict would go on for so long. I was thinking I could go back to my academy after a week and train once again. But things kept getting worse. In 2024, I realised one day, suddenly, that I will never be able to go back to the academy and I will never be able to see my friends and coaches ever again," she says.

Unlike Joel, who lost most of his memorabilia from his time as a football player for Manipur, Tingmila managed to save her medals and bring them to Chennai with her. Reminiscing isn't always helpful. "Sometimes I look at them and I remember how I used to play and how much I achieved. And then I feel bad because I know that can't happen anymore," she says.

While Tingmila misses the chance to fight in the ring, she also — despite the animosities that now exist between communities in Manipur — misses her teammates and her coaches. "I still keep in touch with some of my friends from the academy. Sometimes, I keep in touch with my coach, Ronald Singh. He is still coaching in the academy. He is my favourite coach. He is the one who helped me a lot when I started. Every coach is good and helps, but he was particularly my favourite. After I escaped, he used to ask me where I was and what I was doing. He encouraged me to find a way to continue boxing and my career," she says.

There has been less communication with others. "Mary Kom ma'am was very nice to us when I was at the academy. I've actually stayed at her home in Delhi when I was competing at the Khelo India Games. Her husband, Onler sir, has picked me up in his car also. But since the war, I have not spoken to them. I also haven't heard anything from the state federation," says Tingmila, who now hopes to become a coach and start her own academy someday.